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THE GIRL WHO FOUND HER WORDS



*A bedtime story about a voice that takes its time — and the day
everyone finally listened.*

BY MK PARRISH • \$14

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A NOTE BEFORE THE STORY

Some children's words come out in a rush, easy and quick.

And some children's words take their time. They catch, and repeat, and get stuck behind the teeth, and have to be coaxed out one careful piece at a time. Children who stutter, or who are shy of speaking, learn very young that the world is impatient — that people finish their sentences for them, or look away, or fill the silence before they can.

This is a story for those children. It is about a girl named Willa, whose words took their time, and about the day her kingdom learned that a voice worth hearing is worth waiting for.

Read it unhurried — the way you'd want someone to wait for Willa. And when it ends, tell the child beside you the truest thing in it: *your words are worth waiting for. Take all the time you need.*

THE GIRL WHO FOUND HER WORDS

In a kingdom that loved a good story, there lived a girl named Willa, whose words took their time.

It was a kingdom built on talking. Every year it held the Great Telling — a festival where, one by one, the people stood in the square and told a story, and the whole kingdom listened, and it was the most wonderful day of the year. Children practiced for it for months. To stand up at the Great Telling and tell your story well was the proudest thing a person could do.

Willa loved stories more than anyone. Her head was full of them — brave ones and funny ones and stories so beautiful they made her chest ache. But when Willa tried to say them out loud, her words took their time. The first sound would catch, and c-c-catch, and get stuck somewhere behind her teeth, and she would have to wait and try again, gently, until it came loose.

And the kingdom, which loved a good story, was not very good at waiting.

When Willa spoke, people finished her sentences for her. They looked away, embarrassed for her. Some of the children laughed, and some of the grown-ups did the thing that was almost worse — they got a pained, hurrying look, as if her slowness were a splinter they wished someone would pull out. So slowly, Willa learned to do the saddest thing a girl full of stories can do.

She stopped talking.

She kept all her stories inside, where they were safe, where nobody could rush them. And everyone decided Willa simply had nothing to say.

They were so wrong. Willa had *everything* to say. She just needed a kingdom patient enough to hear it.

Now, the year Willa turned ten, a strange trouble came to the kingdom.

The Great Telling arrived, and the square filled up, and the first teller stood to begin — and found she could not remember her story. Neither could the next teller, or the one after that. A grey forgetting had settled over the kingdom. All the fast talkers, all the quick and easy tellers, opened their mouths and found the stories had slipped right through their rushing fingers, the way water does when you grab at it too fast. They had told their tales so quickly, so carelessly, for so many years, that they had never really *held* them. And now, when it counted, the stories were gone.

The kingdom was in despair. A Great Telling with nothing to tell! The wonderful day, ruined.

And in the very back of the square, a quiet voice said, "I remember one."

Nobody heard it, at first. But Willa's older brother, who loved her, heard. And he stood up on a bench and shouted, "My sister remembers a story! Willa remembers!" And he looked around at the whole impatient kingdom with fire in his eyes and said the bravest thing anyone said that day: "But you have to *let her tell it.* All the way. However long it takes."

The square went quiet. Every face turned to Willa.

Her heart pounded. The old fear rose up — the catching, the sticking, the waiting eyes. But her brother was looking at her like she was worth the wait, and for the first time, the kingdom was silent enough to hold her.

So Willa stood up. And she began.

The first word caught, and c-c-caught, and got stuck behind her teeth. And here is the thing that had never happened before in all of Willa's life:

Nobody rushed her.

Nobody finished it for her. Nobody looked away. The whole kingdom simply waited — patient and still and leaning in — and let the word come loose in its own time. And it did. And then the next one. And Willa, who had held

her stories safe and secret for so many years, began to tell the most beautiful story the kingdom had ever heard.

Because that was the secret nobody had guessed. All those years Willa wasn't talking, she had been *keeping*. Holding her stories carefully, turning them over, learning them by heart in a way the fast talkers never had to. Her words took their time — and so every single one of them had been chosen, and polished, and meant. She did not have less to say than the others.

She had more. She had been saving it.

Willa told her story all the way to the end, catches and all, and when she finished, the square was so quiet you could hear the wind. And then the whole kingdom rose to its feet and roared — the loudest, longest cheer in the history of the Great Telling — for the girl whose words took their time.

After that, the kingdom that loved a good story learned to love something new: the pause before the word. The catch that meant a careful teller was choosing exactly the right thing to say. And every year at the Great Telling, the most honored teller of all, the one the whole kingdom leaned in to hear, was Willa — who was never, ever rushed again.

THE END — AND YOUR BEGINNING

The world is in a terrible hurry.

If your words take their time — if they catch, and stick, and have to be coaxed out one careful piece at a time — the hurrying world will try to finish them for you, or look away, or decide you have nothing to say.

The hurrying world is wrong.

Willa did not win the Great Telling by learning to talk fast like everybody else. She won it by being exactly who she was: a girl whose words took their time, and were *worth* the time, every single one. Your voice is not too slow. It is careful. It is chosen. It is worth waiting for.

So take all the time you need. Let the word catch, and try again, gently, the way Willa did. The right people — the ones who love you, like Willa's brother — will lean in and wait. And one day, when the fast talkers have rushed right past the thing that matters, you will be the one who held it, and kept it, and can finally tell it true.

The kingdom is leaning in.

Take your time. We're listening.

This is a tale from **The Little Rewrites** *— bedtime stories from MK Parrish for children who are learning that they get to write their own happily ever after, exactly as they are. More stories, and the free read-aloud guide for grown-ups, are waiting at* **mkparrish.com.**

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